Even R&AW officials found it difficult to assuage concerns of the different political factions and manage the 'peculiar' zero-sum political landscape of Afghanistan.[100] Interviews with Indian intelligence practitioners and policymakers show that the partisans versus conciliators debate about the post-Bonn political dispensation was not just influenced by the three core drivers of India's foreign policy towards Afghanistan, but also by the disconnect between policymakers in New Delhi and those enabling and implementing policy on the ground in Afghanistan. India developed tremendous goodwill and political capital in Afghanistan that New Delhi could channel in a politically favourable direction, but India often fell short of using this capital for political gains. Trapped in rhetoric to broaden constituencies among Pashtun communities, the conciliators' engage-with-all approach yielded limited results at best, and confused many and alienated some Afghans at worst.

But there was another, highly appreciative, viewpoint on India's conciliatory approach. This came from Karzai's political team. Former deputy foreign minister of Afghanistan, Jawed Ludin, categorically states that 'the shift that we [Afghanistan] saw in India from a faction-based approach to a state-to-state relationship was very crucial'.[101] India was the first country to shed the 1990s civil war inhibitions and focus on the central Afghan government as the main interlocutor. He argues that the other good thing about India's conciliatory approach was that it 'understood our [Afghan] imperatives for engaging with Pakistan. In trying to work with them [Pakistan], and they [Indians] were very careful about that concern of working with Pakistan'.[102] Topping up this political shift with tangible 'gifts' such as big and small aid projects, scholarship program, and electricity, only won more accolades for the conciliators from the Afghan government. Ludin's successor, Ershad Ahmadi, and Afghanistan's former ambassador to Pakistan, Janan Musazai, also appreciated India's conciliatory approach.

For Ahmadi, India did try to have a holistic approach in its dealing with Afghanistan's different political groupings. 'I think there was the fact that India tried to embrace the new Afghanistan, the new leadership, and engage on all aspects of Afghan reconstruction on the national level. And itself tried to correct that sort of partisan perception of moral and traditional support', he says.[103]